# The Employee Is the Audience Nobody Is Building For

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Translating emerging tech into experiences and systems people adopt
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Your company just spent six figures on a mandatory learning module. Forty-five minutes. Click to advance. A quiz at the end. Congratulations, your team is now "aligned."

Meanwhile, three floors up, your VP of People is trying to figure out why engagement scores are flat.

The corporate learning industry has somehow convinced itself that the same format that failed in middle school will work on adults who already know everything is wrong with it. Clip-art explainer videos from 2009. Animated modules voiced by someone who sounds like they'd rather be anywhere else. Compliance checkboxes dressed up as development. The entire category looks like it was designed by people who have never once asked whether any of it actually works.

It doesn't. And the brands that are serious about their people know it.

There's a category of experiential work that almost nobody in this industry talks about out loud. Not because it's rare — but because agencies haven't figured out how to position it, and the buyers for it aren't at the same conferences as everyone else.

It's called **B2E**. Business-to-employee. And right now, while every agency in the experiential space is fighting over the same consumer-facing briefs, this lane is nearly empty.

I looked. Search "employee experiential agency" or "B2E internal experience" and here's what you find: a staffing company that literally named itself Brand 2 Experience, a handful of internal comms consultancies focused on messaging strategy, HR tech platforms selling intranet portals, and a few small European agencies that list employee experience as a service category. There are people working in this space.

What doesn't exist — at least not as a named, proactive specialty with production credentials behind it — is an experiential agency that builds immersive physical environments for internal audiences the way the best agencies build consumer-facing ones. The VP of People or Head of L&D commissioning a multi-cohort leadership development program for hundreds of executives is not being actively marketed to by anyone at that level. Which is either a massive oversight or the most obvious white space in experiential right now. I think it's both.

What I know for certain is that we've been doing this work for years — at Nike, and for other organizations that hold the internal experience to the same standard as everything else they put their name on. And the most important thing it's taught us is that the rules are completely different.

The most complex version of this problem looks something like this: a large, Fortune 100, culturally significant organization has a dense strategic document — 70-plus pages of financial and operational concepts that leadership needs the entire global management layer to not just read, but genuinely internalize. The document is rigorous and important. It is also a document. The right answer isn't a better presentation. It's a *room* — a walkable, immersive environment where every section becomes a physical station, where complex concepts become interactive simulations, where employees make real decisions and see real tradeoffs in real time. Groups move through it in cohorts. It scales from the boardroom to the broader organization over weeks. It lives beyond the event as a digital experience. The document still exists. The room made it real.

That's the gap B2E Experiences fill. And it's a gap no amount of slide advancement solves.

But here's where it gets harder than consumer work. When you're building for employees at a brand with genuine culture and standards — like a "Nike", a brand with both — the bar resets entirely. The audience isn't strangers encountering your brand for the first time. These are people who live inside the brand every day, who have taste calibrated by years of proximity to the real thing. They can feel the difference between something built with intention and something that appeared on a vendor list. We've learned this directly: a keychain at a corporate event signals the opposite of what you intended. A trinket says "we did the minimum." At that point you'd have been better off doing nothing at all.

The work that lands for this audience is built around what the organization actually believes about its people. We've executed large-scale employee events for brands where the culture is so distinctive and the standards so high that "produce the event" would be a failure before setup begins — the event has to be an expression of the brand's relationship with its own team, at the same level of quality they hold everything else. We've built leadership development environments that run across multiple cohorts, rebuilt entirely each time, with custom brand identities, personalized materials, and physical artifacts designed to outlive the program itself. And we've built immersive spaces for organizations to do internal education and entertainment in environments that feel like the brand — not like a rented conference room dressed up with a logo.

Each of these taught us the same thing: B2E is not just a different audience. It's a different physics.

Consumer activations have a certain freedom — you're meeting a stranger, you have minutes, you create a peak moment and move on. If it doesn't land perfectly, there are ten other channels to reach that person tomorrow. They walk away? Fine. That's the nature of the game.

Your employees can't walk away. Or more precisely: you don't want them to. When an internal experience fails to engage, the financial stakes are immediate and real. Replacing a mid-level employee costs companies an estimated 50 to 200 percent of their annual salary once you factor in recruiting, onboarding, and lost productivity. Disengaged employees who stay are worse — Gallup estimates they cost U.S. businesses roughly $550 billion a year in lost productivity. The consumer activation that didn't quite land costs you a brand impression. The internal experience that didn't land costs you people, alignment, and compounding organizational drag.

This is also why B2E is genuinely different from wayfinding, office branding, or the fun wall mural in the breakroom. Those things matter, but they're decoration. What we're talking about is content — deeply collaborative, strategically aligned, built from the inside out. It's not a brief that arrives as part of a marketing campaign. It's a co-creation between agency and brand that typically reports directly to a CEO or senior leader, because what's at stake is how the organization understands itself. That was true with Nike. There's no version of this work where you hand over a deck and say "produce this." The execution is the message.

The brands getting this right have figured out that the internal audience is as valuable as the external one. The experience you build for your own people signals everything about what kind of company you actually are.

That signal deserves a builder, not a vendor.

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